The Byzantine Empire and Orthodox Eastern Europe ‘Proper’

In the Catholic Church the last couple of decades have seen increased efforts to reach out to the Orthodox world. This interest in things Orthodox intensified with the late Pope John Paul II, who was very impressed by the spirituality of the Eastern Churches and, in particular, by the veneration of Mary in the Orthodox tradition.

This seems to be somehow at odds with the baroque features of Central Europe. In fact, John Paul II’s interest in things Orthodox may be equally confusing for those trying to understand Eastern Europe. His homeland Poland, like the rest of Central Europe, is traditionally Catholic, not Orthodox. His own comments from the balcony of St Peter’s on the very day of his election that he had come from ‘a far land’ did not help either. (His native city of Krakow is actually closer to Rome than Berlin, but at the time of his election in 1978 it definitely felt distant in space and time.) His interest in Eastern spirituality was, above all, religious, though some think that he was also concerned about mending the uneasy relationship that has existed between Russians and Poles through the centuries and, of course, between the Orthodox and the Catholic Church – something that is dear to Pope Francis too. Deep down, the interest of the late Slav pope in things Orthodox was also a result of the fact that he was a Slav himself and that an important part of the Slav world is Orthodox.

In striving to be everything to everyone, Western Christianity (above all the Protestant churches, but also the Catholic Church) has gone to great lengths to strip itself of those elements that are conditioned by national cultures and old traditions, and which are not strictly related to religion as such. Churches started to use not only the vernacular but also plain everyday language. They absolved believers of the need for undue ceremonials, excessive piety and unnecessary regulations. Much, though not all, of the Church’s ‘red tape’ has gone. Religion and its liturgies lie barer than ever before. This is certainly the case in the Catholic Church in English-speaking countries where the influence of the Anglican Church and the long disenfranchisement of the Catholic Church have made the interiors